Philosophy · Epistemology · Perception

Berkeley's Idealism

Student workbook: work through it alongside the slideshow, or on your own to catch up and revise.

Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

This workbook helps you take in, check and use the ideas from the lesson on George Berkeley's idealism. Each part starts with a short recap, then gives you tasks. You do not have to finish every part in one go: tick off each part as you complete it, and come back to the rest later.

Tasks build up in difficulty: first you recall the key terms, then you fill in tables, then you explain, and finally you write 5-mark and 12-mark exam answers.

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Key idea Note on the spec: idealism sits in Paper 1, Epistemology – Perception as a source of knowledge (AQA 7172). Berkeley's attack on the primary/secondary distinction, the master argument and the role of God are all named content.

Part 01 Key terms

Before you can follow Berkeley's arguments you need the vocabulary. Read the definitions in the glossary at the back if you get stuck.

Task 1.1 Match each term to its definition by writing the correct letter in the box.

Term	Letter	Definitions
Substance		A. An image or perception present to the mind.
Primary quality		B. A quality that depends on a mind to exist, e.g. colour, taste, smell.
Secondary quality		C. The view that only minds and their ideas exist.
Idea		D. The underlying 'thing' that stands under an object's properties and stays the same while they change.
Idealism		E. A quality that belongs to the object itself, independent of any mind, e.g. shape, size, number.
Mind-dependent		F. Existing only if, and while, a mind perceives it.

Task 1.2 Substance is 'that which stands under the properties'. Explain this using the example of a chair that is reupholstered and fades in colour.

Task 1.3 Give two examples of primary qualities and two examples of secondary qualities.

Primary qualities (mind-independent)	Secondary qualities (mind-dependent)
1.	1.
2.	2.

Part 02 What is idealism?

> **Key Thesis**
>
> Idealism: all that exists are minds and the ideas in minds. There are no mind-independent material objects. Berkeley's slogan is esse est percipi – 'to be is to be perceived'.

Key idea Spelling check: the Latin is esse est percipi. You may see it misspelt in notes – learn the correct form for the exam.

Berkeley is not saying that tables and trees are unreal. He is saying that what a table is just is a collection of ideas – what you see, feel and hear when you encounter it. There is nothing 'behind' those ideas.

Task 2.1 Put the slogan esse est percipi into your own words.

Task 2.2 True or false? Tick one column and correct any false statement.

Statement	True	False	Correction (if false)
Berkeley thinks physical objects are illusions.			
For Berkeley, only minds and ideas exist.			
An idealist believes objects exist independently of minds.			
A table, for Berkeley, is a collection of ideas.			

Task 2.3 Berkeley gives three key arguments for idealism. List them.

	Argument
1	
2	
3	

Part 03 Argument 1: there is no material substance

Berkeley asks us to imagine taking away every property of an object, one by one: its colour, its extension (how much space it takes up), its weight, and so on. When every property is gone, what is left? Berkeley says: nothing. So the idea of a substance underneath the properties is empty.

The argument in standard form

1. If material substance exists, it is something over and above an object's properties.
2. If we remove every property of an object in thought, nothing is left over.
3. So we have no idea of anything over and above an object's properties.
4. Therefore, the idea of material substance is empty – there is no such thing as material substance.

Task 3.1 Complete the 'subtraction' table for an apple. In the last row, say what is left.

Take away...	What would we lose from our experience of the apple?
Its colour	
Its shape / extension	
Its weight	
Its taste and smell	
What is left?	

Task 3.2 Which premise do you think is weakest? Explain why someone might reject it.

Part 04 Argument 2: attacking the primary/secondary distinction

John Locke distinguished primary qualities (such as shape, size and number), which he thought really belong to the object, from secondary qualities (such as colour, taste, smell and sound), which exist only as sensations in a perceiving mind. Locke used this to explain perceptual variation: water can feel warm to one hand and cold to the other, so warmth is in us, not the water.

Berkeley turns Locke's reasoning against him. Primary qualities also vary with the perceiver. A tower looks smaller from far away. Press the side of your eye and you can see two chairs instead of one, so even number changes. If variation shows that secondary qualities are mind-dependent, then by the same reasoning primary qualities are mind-dependent too.

Key idea Berkeley's move: same reasoning, same conclusion. If perceptual variation makes colour mind-dependent, it makes size and number mind-dependent as well.

Task 4.1 Complete the comparison table.

	Locke	Berkeley
Are primary qualities mind-dependent?		
Are secondary qualities mind-dependent?		
Example used		
What really exists?		

Task 4.2 Fill in the perceptual-variation table. The first row is done for you.

Quality	Primary or secondary?	How can it vary for different perceivers?
Colour	Secondary	A red apple looks grey in dim light, or different to someone who is colour-blind.
Size		
Number		
Temperature		
Shape		

Task 4.3 A Lockean could reply: 'Things look different sizes from different distances, but we can measure their real size with a ruler.' How might Berkeley respond?

Part 05 Argument 3: the master argument

In Three Dialogues between Hylas and Philonous (1713), Berkeley's spokesperson Philonous challenges Hylas (whose name comes from the Greek for 'matter') to conceive of something existing outside every mind. If he can, Berkeley will concede. Hylas thinks this is easy: he simply imagines a tree or a house existing on its own, unperceived.

Philonous replies that this is a contradiction. In imagining the unperceived tree, Hylas is himself conceiving it, so it is not unconceived at all. We can never think of a thing existing outside all minds, because the thinking puts it in a mind.

> *Paraphrase of the exchange: Hylas says nothing could be easier than to conceive of a tree or house existing by itself, unperceived by any mind. Philonous replies that it is a contradiction to conceive of a thing which is unconceived.*
>
> — Paraphrased from Berkeley, Three Dialogues between Hylas and Philonous, First Dialogue (check your edition for exact wording and page)

The argument in standard form

1. If mind-independent objects are possible, we can conceive of an object existing unconceived.
2. But whenever we conceive of an object, it is conceived – by us.
3. So we cannot conceive of an object existing unconceived.
4. Therefore, the idea of a mind-independent object is incoherent.

Task 5.1 Who are the two characters, and what does each one stand for?

Character	What does he represent?
Hylas	
Philonous	

Task 5.2 Critics argue the master argument confuses two things: (a) the act of conceiving and (b) what is conceived. Imagining a tree that nobody perceives is not the same as imagining a tree that nobody imagines. Explain this objection in your own words.

Part 06 Where do our ideas come from? The role of God

If only minds and ideas exist, where do our ideas of the world come from? Berkeley uses an argument from elimination: list all the possibilities, rule them out one by one, and accept what is left.

Task 6.1 Complete the elimination table.

Possible source of our ideas	Ruled out? (Yes / No)	Reason
1. The external material world		
2. Our own minds		
3. The mind of God		

Key idea The key contrast: ideas of imagination are weak and under our control; ideas of sense are vivid, orderly and involuntary – I can't choose what I see when I open my eyes.

For Berkeley, God comprehends all ideas in his mind, but does not experience them as we do – otherwise God would suffer pain, which Berkeley thought impossible for a perfect being.

Task 6.2 Why can't our sense experiences come from our own minds? Use the word involuntary.

Task 6.3 God also explains why objects continue to exist when no human perceives them. Explain how.

Part 07 Pulling it together

Task 7.1 Summarise each argument in one sentence, then say how it supports idealism.

Argument	One-sentence summary	How it supports idealism
No material substance		
Primary/secondary attack		
Master argument		
Argument from elimination (God)		

Task 7.2 Which of Berkeley's arguments do you find strongest, and why? Give one reason and one possible objection.

Part 08

Exam practice: 5-mark questions

Key idea 5-mark questions are AO1 only. Define key terms, set out the reasoning step by step, and use precise terminology. No evaluation is needed.

Model structure

1. Define the key term(s) in the question precisely.
2. Set out the argument or view in logical steps – premises leading to a conclusion.
3. Use an example to illustrate one step.
4. Finish by stating the conclusion clearly.

Question Explain Berkeley's idealism. (5 marks)

Question Explain Berkeley's argument against material substance. (5 marks)

Question Explain Berkeley's master argument. (5 marks)

Part 09 Exam practice: 12-mark questions

Key idea 12-mark questions are also AO1: a full, precise and well-integrated explanation, with each step logically connected. Show how the parts of the argument fit together, not just what they are.

Model structure

1. Introduction: define the key terms and state the conclusion Berkeley reaches.
2. Context: set out the view being attacked (e.g. Locke's primary/secondary distinction, or the material world as a source of ideas).
3. Step-by-step reasoning: explain each premise, with examples.
4. Connections: show how each step leads to the next.
5. Conclusion: restate what has been shown and how it supports idealism.

Planning grid

Paragraph	Your plan for Question 1
Introduction	
Context	
Reasoning 1	
Reasoning 2	
Conclusion	

Question 1 Outline and explain Berkeley's argument against the primary/secondary quality distinction. (12 marks)

Question 2 Explain why Berkeley thinks that our ideas have their origin in the mind of God. (12 marks)

Part 10 Glossary

Term	Definition
Argument from elimination	An argument that lists every possible option and rules them out until only one remains, which is then accepted.
Esse est percipi	Latin for 'to be is to be perceived': Berkeley's slogan for idealism.
Extension	The property of taking up space; having size and shape.
Hylas	Character in Berkeley's Three Dialogues who defends the existence of matter. His name comes from the Greek for 'matter'.
Idea	For Berkeley, any object of perception or thought present to a mind – a sensation, image or thought.
Idealism	The view that only minds and their ideas exist; there are no mind-independent material objects.
Involuntary	Not under our control. Berkeley stresses that ideas of sense are involuntary, unlike ideas of imagination.
Master argument	Berkeley's argument that we cannot conceive of an object existing unconceived, so mind-independent objects are inconceivable.
Mind-dependent	Existing only if, and while, a mind perceives it.
Mind-independent	Existing whether or not any mind perceives it.
Perceptual variation	The way an object appears differently to different perceivers or under different conditions.
Philonous	Berkeley's spokesperson in the Three Dialogues; the name means 'lover of mind'.
Primary quality	For Locke, a quality that belongs to the object itself, independent of the mind: e.g. shape, size, motion, number.
Secondary quality	For Locke, a power in the object to produce sensations in us, such as colour, taste, smell, sound; as experienced, these exist only in the mind.
Substance	That which 'stands under' an object's properties and remains the same while they change.